

The Power of Kaii



Devesh R. Agarwal, Managing Director, Infomart (India) Pvt Ltd

// We wanted to develop an intelligent, low-cost and flexible handheld computing platform that would serve as an engine for a variety of vertical applications //

With miniaturisation emerging across every form of technology, it comes as no surprise that there has been tremendous advancement in the field of portable computing over the past year. Ultra portable Tablet PCs and powerful handhelds are getting closer to the end user with enhancements in fabrication technology and faster, more power-wise processors. This trend is exemplified in India by the announcement of the Simputer, bringing portable computing closer to the masses.

The newest device to hit the Indian handheld computing scene is the Kaii, an indigenously developed handheld that boasts robust processing power, affordability and a high level of configurability, making it suitable across a varied cross-section of application areas. We spoke to the developers of the Kaii. Following are excerpts from an e-mail interview:

■ What was the inspiration for Kaii?

The idea originated in August 2001. We wanted to develop an intelligent, low-cost and flexible handheld computing platform that would serve as an engine for a variety of vertical applications. These include a PDA, inventory, e-governance, ticketing, GPS, etc.

■ What is your vision for Kaii?

The Kaii is a multi-purpose handheld computing platform, which can serve a variety of market needs and applications. It has always been our vision to make the platform available to both hardware and software developers and original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) who can take it to new markets by applying their own unique ideas and skills.

■ What are the advantages offered by Kaii apart from the obvious advantage of cost?

Kaii is not merely a PDA. Its biggest advantage is its flexibility, USB Host control and state-of-art power management. Another unique feature targeted at larger OEMs is the concept of mass customisation, where the OEM can choose the hardware and software components. No handheld manufacturer has offered this concept before. The existing Palm and Pocket PC devices offer only a USB client, while Kaii has both, host and client. Through the USB Host, external USB devices such as the mouse, keyboard, hard disk and printer can be connected. For instance, when the Kaii is coupled with an 802.11b Wi-Fi card, an OEM can offer a special purpose corporate workstation for under Rs 15,000. This workstation can be complete with all

office automation software, an e-mail client, a world standard Web-browser and a Sun certified Java Virtual Machine. Companies such as Insurance and FMCGs can equip large sales forces with a Kaii, loaded with their custom applications. This can be carried to client locations, the orders taken on the spot and the person can upload the orders to the corporate ERP using Wi-Fi when he or she returns. The Kaii can also be included in the handheld GPS receiver, e-books and information kiosk markets.

■ How does it compete with other PDAs in functionality and power?

In the PDA avatar, the Kaii offers all the power and multimedia features of a Pocket PC. Like Palm OS and Microsoft Pocket PC, the standard software includes MS Office compatible software for word processing, spreadsheets, presentations, a Web browser, an e-mail client and a Sun certified Java Virtual Machine. Feature wise, KAIi is highly competitive as against a Palm or any model of Microsoft Pocket PC. It also has many games such as *Asteroids*, *Tetris*, etc., and software to sync with MS Outlook. It has a CF card slot, a Multi-Media Card (MMC) slot and infrared. Additionally, the Kaii is 'world ready' due to its double-bit ability and has language packs for most languages available either for free or for a charge from the vast Linux community. In addition, the USB Host expands and extends the Kaii PDA's functionality.

Most companies sell their PDAs at low price initially and then cash in on the proprietary accessories. A Kaii owner is given many non-proprietary and hence, inexpensive choices.

■ What kind of response has it received? Do you plan to take it to foreign markets as well?

We are overwhelmed by the kind of interest generated. It was designed for the global community of which India is a part. We took a lot of inspiration from India in the diversity of applications required, as well as the cost competitiveness required. Kaii is a platform for people to bring their ideas to fruition. Its concept has generated interest from all corners of the world.

■ Who is your target audience?

In the PDA avatar, the audience is those who seek value for money. As a platform, it is for all the hardware and software developers, and OEMs who have a unique idea and need a platform to help bring it to fruition. ■

As communicated to Marco D'Souza